

Rwanda



Rwanda lies just south of the equator in east central Africa, far from the nearest sea port. Since independence from France in 1962, ethnic tensions have dominated politics.



GEOGRAPHY

A series of plateaus descend from the ridge of volcanic peaks in the west to the Akagera River on the eastern border. The Great Rift Valley also passes through this region.



CLIMATE

Tropical, though tempered by the altitude. Two wet seasons are separated by a dry season, from June to August. Heaviest rain in the west.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

For over 500 years the cattle-owning Tutsi minority were politically dominant over the land-owning Hutu. In 1959, violent revolt led to a reversal of the roles. Ethnic tensions are fierce; in the most recent violence, in 1994, over 800,000 people, mostly Tutsi, were massacred in an act of state-backed genocide; trials are ongoing. Most people live at subsistence level.



THE ECONOMY

Rwanda is reliant on aid, but (given stability) could become a big coffee and tea producer. Exports tin, coltan, and iron ore. Ecotourism is growing. Possible oil and gas reserves. Landlocked: high transportation costs.



INSIGHT: *Rwanda's parliament in 2008 was the first in the world to have more women members than men*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Rwanda

DATE OF FORMATION: 1962

CAPITAL: Kigali

POPULATION: 10 million

TOTAL AREA: 10,169 sq. miles
(26,338 sq. km)

DENSITY: 1038 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Kinyarwanda*, French*, Kiswahili, English*

RELIGIONS: Catholic 56%, traditional beliefs 25%, Muslim 10%, Protestant 9%

ETHNIC MIX: Hutu 90%, Tutsi 9%, other (including Twa) 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Rwanda franc = 100 centimes